and adventurers to prosper.

One of the most famous of these was Gerald the Fearless, a Portuguese soldier of fortune who assembled an army of freebooters and campaigned recklessly into the area known as the Extremadura: outside Portuguese borders, well into Almohad territory. Sometime around 1165, he attacked the city of Evora. Later chroniclers insist that, when his soldiers balked, Gerald went up the walls himself by driving spears between the stones as a makeshift ladder and came back down with a couple of heads. Evora's coat of arms commemorated the event, as did the epic poem *Os Lusiadas,* written in the sixteenth century by Luis Vaz de Camões:

> Watch this one, shinning down his lance
> Back to the ambush, with the heads
> Of the two watchmen, and so captures
> Evora with subterfuge and daring.[8]

The capture of Evora was the first in a series of victories for Gerald the Fearless and his band; he went on to seize at least four more towns.

The successes alarmed the Almohads, but were even more troubling to the Christian kings; Gerald seemed to be on the path to a private kingdom of his own. When Gerald laid siege to the Almohad city of Badajoz in 1169, Afonso Henriques of Portugal and Ferdinand II of León banded together to drive him off.

Gerald now found himself without a home. He made overtures of peace to the king of Portugal; Afonso Henriques, who broke his leg in the fight for Badajoz and was never again able to ride without pain, was not forgiving. So in 1172 Gerald offered to enter the service of the Almohad caliph Yusuf I instead.

The caliph accepted his allegiance and stationed him in the Moroccan desert. This was not a posting that showed great faith in Gerald's loyalties, and, sure enough, within months Gerald was carrying on a second set of secret negotiations with Afonso Henriques, proposing to hand over his new territory so that the Portuguese would have a base of operations from which to attack the Almohad heartland. Yusuf I, getting wind of the messages, sent soldiers to arrest Gerald; whether or not by design, they killed him in the process.[9]

The siege of Badajoz had temporarily put the Almohad ruler of Badajoz and the two Christian kings on the same side. This blurring of allegiances troubled Yusuf I, and in the summer of 1171 he transported twenty thousand soldiers across the Strait of Gibraltar, aiming to firm up his hold on the